the AAP leader was in danger of isolating himself. His decision to contest over 450 Lok Sabha seats hadn't really taken off and AAP workers appeared to be in a state of drift. Kejriwal was looking to position himself as the principal challenger to Modi; he also needed to seize the media mindspace once again. Varanasi was the place to do so. This would be another David versus Goliath fight—Kejriwal was convinced he had nothing to lose.

Kejriwal's entry upset Shah's calculations once again. He had been hoping for an easy ride for Modi; now Varanasi was becoming a more complicated seat than originally anticipated. Shah's first problem was within the party. The sitting Varanasi MP was Dr Murli Manohar Joshi, the veteran BJP leader who saw himself next only to Vajpayee and Advani in the party hierarchy. Dr Joshi's loyalists would often tell me, 'He has all the credentials to be the party's prime ministerial candidate. You people must project him better.'

Few others within the BJP, though, seemed to share Dr Joshi's opinion of his own capabilities. His self-image may have been of a scholarly voice with a doctorate in nuclear physics from Allahabad University, but on the ground, he had no real support base. In Varanasi, where he had won the 2009 elections by just 17,000 votes, the anger against Dr Joshi was palpable. 'He should spend less time talking about WTO and more time here in Varanasi dealing with our local problems,' they told me. When Dr Joshi was denied re-election from Varanasi, he initially sulked but then realized he was better off in moving to Kanpur.

Shah's other difficulty in Varanasi lay in the sheer demographics of the constituency. With a population of nearly 3 lakhs, Muslims comprised nearly 15 per cent of the voters. OBCs and Dalits made up sizeable chunks too. The upper castes were the backbone of the BJP, but Shah needed to make a dent in the other social groups to offset the likely Muslim consolidation. A tie-up with the local Kurmi-dominated Apna Dal, which has a strong base in and around Varanasi, was only the first step (see chapter 5). But Shah knew he needed something bigger to set the Ganga on fire. It was time for a Big Bang event.